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Select Disputations in Scholastic, Positive, and Moral Theology — Part I, Disputation XXXV

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DISPUTATION XXXV. — SCHOLASTIC. — SOLE DOUBT.

Whether it is of faith that this-in-number man is Pontiff.

THIS difficulty is wont to be treated of set purpose by the Scholastics in the matter *de fide*, on 2. 2. at question 1., and by those who dispute against heretics when they treat of the dignity of the Pontiff.

And among Catholics it is certain that it is **not only temerarious and scandalous, but proximate to error**, to deny that **this-in-number man, received without controversy by the Church from the election**, is the true Pontiff.

The question, however, is whether it is **of faith** that this man is Pontiff, in such wise that the contrary is **heresy**.

And indeed, **before Clement VIII, the common sense of the Scholastics, especially of those who committed their writings to print, was that it is not of faith**. And **nearly thirty authors** are cited by more recent writers, from the various Academies of the Church, **in Gaul, Germany, Italy, and Spain**, who so held — to say nothing of many others who so taught in their manuscripts. Bellarmin. *libr. 4. de Pontific. cap. 12*. Cano so taught, 6. *de locis. cap. vltimo*,

whom, as their master, most learned religious of the Dominican family have followed; and Bañes so taught, [a] disciple of Cano, 2. 2. *ad quæstionem* 1. in *articulum* 10, in *prioribus commentarijs*, *dub.* 2. *ad* 2. And Vega, of the Franciscan family, *libr.* 9. in *Tridentin.* *cap.* 39. And who, together with Cano, **were present at the Council of Trent, where they came to know the mind of the Fathers of that Council.**

And the chief argument for this opinion was this: that there appears no principle certain of faith by which it might be proved, from the certitude of faith, that this-in-number man is Pontiff. For although it is certain of faith that the legitimate successor of St. Peter is the true Pontiff, nevertheless that this {p. 219} [col. a] in-number man is the legitimate successor of Peter seems to be established only by human faith, and by a prudent judgment, whereby we judge that his election was legitimate.

And it can be explained from a similar case: for although it is of faith that a host duly consecrated contains the true body of Christ, nevertheless that this-in-number host contains the body of Christ is not of faith absolutely, so long as it is not established that it has been legitimately consecrated.

But in this time, after Clement VIII, the common opinion is that it is of faith that one man in number — for example, Urban VIII — is the supreme Pontiff of the Church: and the Doctors of this opinion speak **of a man received by the Church as Pontiff by common consent, and without any controversy.** The chief argument for this opinion is that from the contrary opinion it would follow that the Pontiff's definition concerning doctrine and the matter of faith does not have sufficient certitude, because it would not be certain that that definition proceeds from a true Pontiff, and from one having legitimate authority for defining and declaring matters of faith. From which doubt several absurdities could follow, and doubts of mind even in men who are pious and well affected toward the affairs of the Church. Which reason some more recent writers explain at length. Let Fr. Suarez be read, in the matter *de fide*, where he treats this doubt, and not a few others who have written after Clement VIII.

This latter opinion pleases me, and its reason: because when a man has been **received by the Church without any controversy**, he receives from Christ the power of defining, jurisdiction over the whole Church, by Christ's institution; otherwise nothing would be firm in the Church from the Pontiff's determination or ordinance.

And therefore it is not necessary, as Fr. Valencia thought it necessary, that this man should define, or do something in relation to the whole Church, in order that he be held as a certain Pontiff; **but election alone, and the acceptance of the Church without any controversy, suffice.**

And from this reasoning the reason of the contrary opinion is resolved: because in the Sacrament of the Eucharist there is nothing certain in particular from which we might gather, with the certitude of faith, that Christ is contained in this-in-number host; whereas **in our case, in the man thus elected there is the power of defining and of governing the whole Church. From which is gathered, with the certitude of faith, that the man thus elected is Pontiff.**

Two things might briefly be asked. One is whether, before Clement VIII, the first opinion was probable. The other is whether, after Clement VIII, it remains probable.

As to the first: in the time of Clement, that opinion was judged by nearly all the learned men of Spain either true, or highly probable, and **deserving no censure.**

As to the second: one or another Doctor has judged it not to be probable. Others, however, have commonly taught the contrary, on the ground that there appears neither a condemnation by a Pontiff, nor a prohibition of his doctrine, such that each one may pass judgment from general principles. **But I judge that at this time it cannot be defended without scandal that the thing is not of faith.**

P. Luisij de Torres select. disp. Pars I.